NY-3 Congressional District 2026 Election Prediction

Econ 109 Fall 2026 - Prof. Languet-Marx
Kate Higginbotham, Fischer Work, Dylan Lam, Julian Panther, Jinghao Wang
November 3rd, 2026

Introduction to Race and District

In 2024, Democrat Tom Suozzi beat Republican and Conservative Michael LiPetri Jr 51.7% to 48.1% (Ballotpedia), now they face a rematch. Figure 1 shows the location of NY-3, making up parts of Nassau County and Queens.

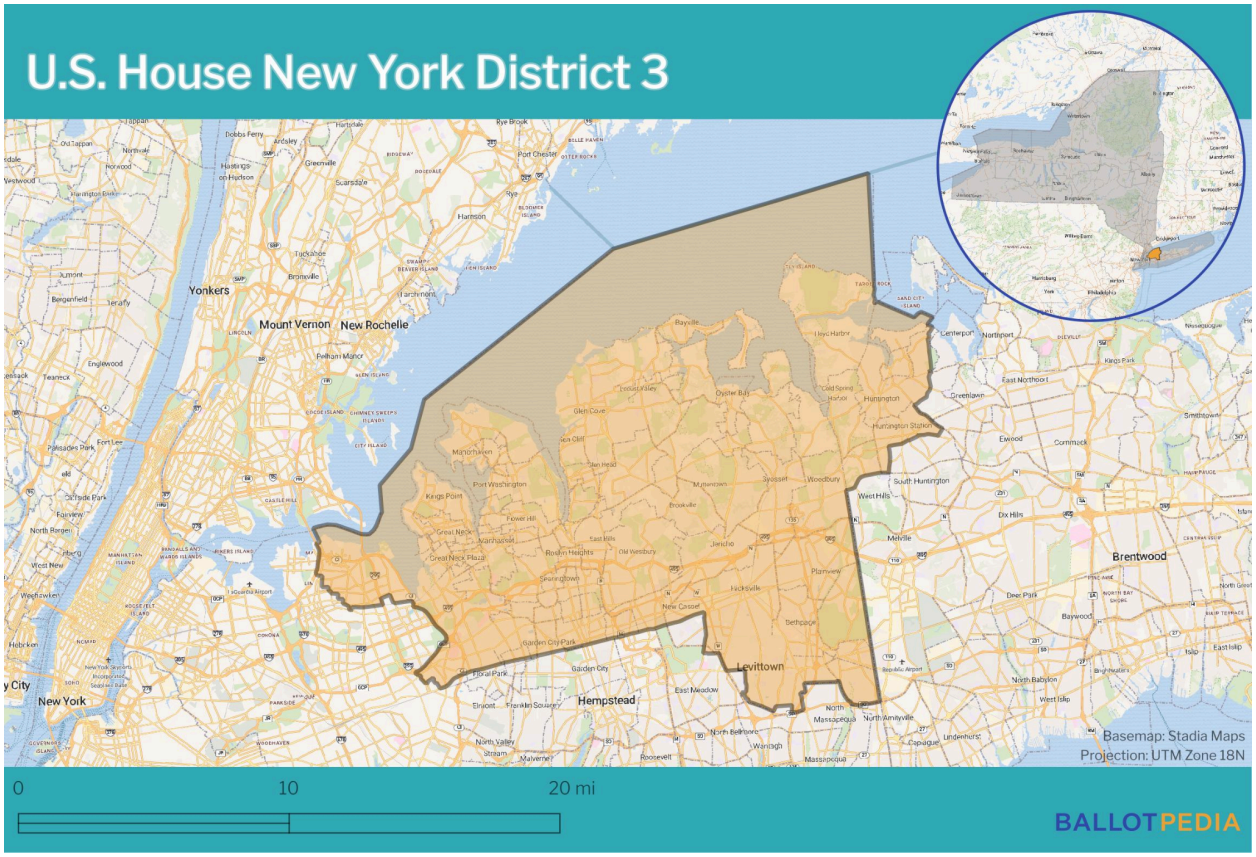


Figure 1. NY-3 Congressional Map Following the 2020 Census Redistricting (Ballotpedia)

The district has generally leaned Democratic in recent Congressional elections, however the size of the margin has varied largely depending on the candidates and the political climate.

The district's voter registration generally favors Democrats with a majority Democratic registered voters compared to Republicans by around 11.5%. However there are around 30% unaffiliated voters indicating the preferences and turnout of independent voters could have a large impact on the outcome.

The 3rd wealthiest district in New York, 13th nationally, NY-3 tends to have voters that lean right on issues such as taxes, inflation, and other economic issues, yet maintain left leaning views on social and cultural issues. Leading the district to be one 1 of 23 New York districts to vote to elect Trump into office; while also voting to elect a Democrat representative simultaneously. This is one example of the split-party view of this district.

Baseline Prediction

Our baseline for the prediction is the 2024 congressional election, which provides the most recent evidence of how voters in the district voted and how they feel about these candidates. We used Democratic +3.6 points as our baseline from Democrat Tom Suozzi beating Republican Michael LiPetri Jr by 51.7% to 48.1%.

To analyze historical voting patterns, we looked at congressional election results from the MIT Election Data and Science Lab's 1976-2024 US House Election Dataset. We filtered the data to include solely New York General elections and calculated the Democratic minus Republican margin for each congressional district, combining candidate votes on multiple party lines.

We restricted our historical comparison and regression to elections from the 2012 election and on due to NY-3 looking very different prior to the redistricting of the district following the 2010 census. The election results in 2008 and 2010 represent a different geographic location and the voters are not directly comparable to the most recent election. In Figure 2, you can see NY-3's Democratic Margin changing substantially between 2010 and 2012, explained majorly by a change in the boundaries of the district rather than an abrupt change in the preferences of the voters.

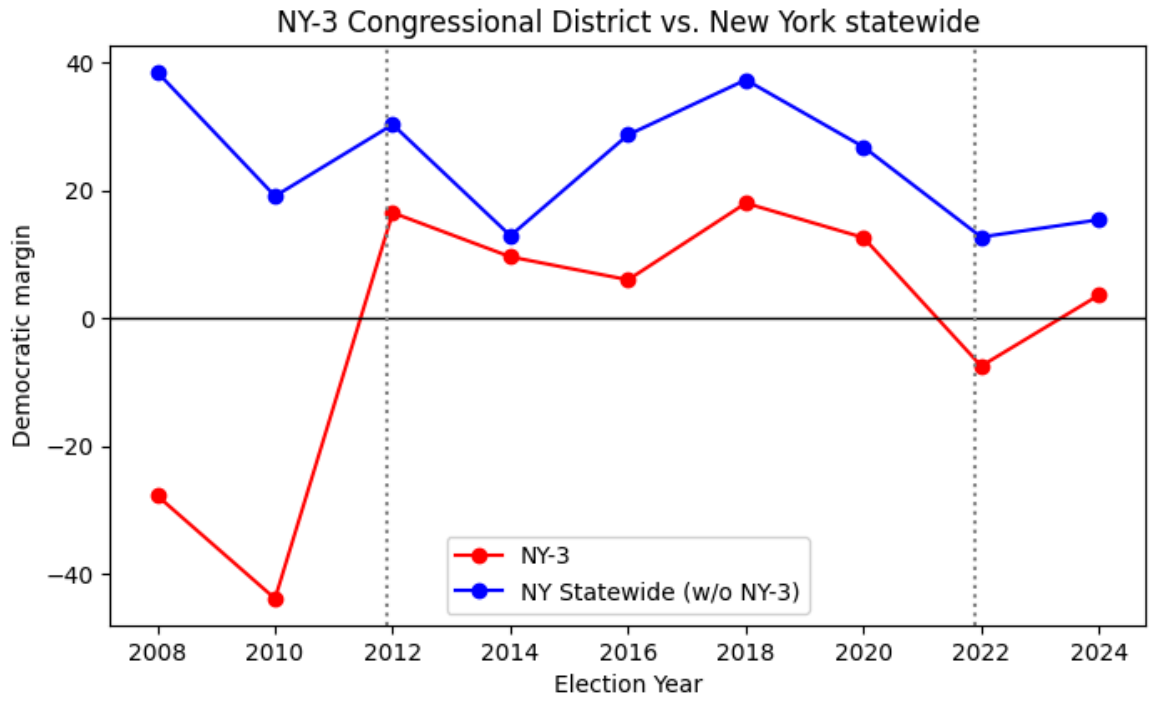


Figure 2. Historical Democratic margins in NY-3 and the rest of the state of NY (excluding district 3) from 2008 to 2024.

The vertical line at 2012 indicates the first election under the new district map following the 2010 census. The vertical line at 2022 indicates the next election under the new district map following the 2020 census. The stark difference between 2010 and 2012 shows the map boundaries changing caused a large leftward shift in the district's voting patterns, more closely resembling the voting patterns of the rest of NY. Based on this stark difference in voter tendencies we restricted the analysis to 2012 onward.

After restricting the analysis to 2012-2024, the historical NY-3 Democratic margins are seen in Table 1.

year	NY-3	NY Statewide (w/o NY-3)
2012	16.5	30.3
2014	9.6	12.9
2016	6.0	28.7
2018	18.0	37.3
2020	12.6	26.8
2022	-7.5	12.7
2024	3.6	15.4

Table 1. Democratic margin (pts) from 2012 to 2024 (the most recent election)

The margins show NY-3 and the rest of the state tend to move together but NY-3 tends to lean more right, by about 15 points on average. This seat is competitive, not tied to one party. In 2022 NY-3 voted George Santos, a Republican, into office, a distinct outlier among the results. The district quickly reverted back to center-left baseline after this outlier result. Due to the fact that this was an outlier and unexpected to repeat, we did not include 2022 in our regression analysis.

Data Components and Sources

To Develop our prediction for the 2026 NY-3 Congressional election, we combined historical election results with current information on statewide political trends, incumbency, and campaign spending. Through these components we can account for the district's historical voting patterns and factors that may influence the outcome of this election.

Our primary historical data source was the MIT Election Data and Science Lab's 1976-2024 US House Election Dataset. We filtered the dataset to include general elections in New York and calculated the Democratic margin in each congressional district through subtracting Republican votes from Democratic votes and dividing by the total votes for the 2 parties. As stated above we focused on NY-3 beginning in 2012 following the 2010 Census remapping and excluding the outlier of the 2022 election. This exclusion of Santos' 2022 win is an important limitation as it may not capture the possibility of a full Republican shift, however it is not reflective of the historical patterns seen in NY-3.

We added statewide election trends using the October 2026 Marist Poll, which stated a Democratic advantage of around 14 points in the statewide generic ballot. We used this margin as an indicator of the current political climate heading into the 2026 elections for our prediction.

We collected information about incumbency and campaign spending from Ballotpedia's NY-3 congressional election coverage and campaign finance page. Incumbency was equal to 1 if a Democrat incumbent was running and 0 otherwise. This variable reflected the potential advantage for Democrats who currently hold the seat. Campaign spending was incorporated through a spending ratio comparing the candidates' financial spending. This measure accounts for differences in campaign resources that may affect voter outreach advertising, and overall campaign viability.

The Model and What Each Source Adds

Our model is an Ordinary Least Squares Regression. Our dependent variable is the Democratic margin in NY-3 which was measured as the percentage-point difference between Democrat and Republican votes. The model had three independent variables: the Democratic in the rest of the state of New York (excluding NY-3), a Democratic incumbency indicator, and the campaign spending ratio. The results of our Regression analysis can be seen in Figure 3 below.

OLS Regression Results

Dep. Variable:	ny3_margin	R-squared:	0.982
Model:	OLS	Adj. R-squared:	0.955
Method:	Least Squares	F-statistic:	36.36
Date:	Tue, 03 Nov 2026	Prob (F-statistic):	0.0269
Time:	04:06:00	Log-Likelihood:	-6.3663
No. Observations:	6	AIC:	20.73
Df Residuals:	2	BIC:	19.90
Df Model:	3		
Covariance Type:	nonrobust		

	coef	std err	t	P>|t|	[0.025	0.975]
const	3.6136	3.481	1.038	0.408	-11.365	18.592
state_margin	0.4076	0.063	6.511	0.023	0.138	0.677
dem_incumbent	10.2489	1.441	7.111	0.019	4.047	16.450
spending	-18.2484	4.300	-4.243	0.051	-36.751	0.254

Omnibus:	nan	Durbin-Watson:	1.809
Prob(Omnibus):	nan	Jarque-Bera (JB):	1.238
Skew:	-1.101	Prob(JB):	0.539
Kurtosis:	3.322	Cond. No.	284.

Figure 3. Our OLS Regression Results using NY State Democratic Margin (w/o NY-3), a Democratic Incumbency Dummy, and Spending Ratios. (Ballotpedia, October 2026).

Our constant coefficient is 3.6136, with a p-value of 0.408. This means the estimated NY-3 Democratic margin would be approximately 3.61 points when all other variables are equal to 0,

however the p-value indicates that this is not statistically significant and we do not have enough evidence to determine the intercept is different from zero. Our constant is mainly included to fit the data rather than serve as a valuable predictor on its own so this result is not as alarming.

The statewide Democratic margin, excluding NY-3, has a coefficient of 0.4076 and a p-value of 0.023 making it statistically significant at the 5% level. This indicates that a 1% point increase in the Democratic margin across NY, excluding NY-3, is associated with an approximately 0.4076% point increase in the Democratic margin in NY-3, holding all other variables constant. This supports our idea that NY-3 follows the trends of the rest of the state.

The Democratic incumbency variable has a coefficient of about 10.25 and a p-value of 0.019 making it statistically significant at the 5% level. This indicates that a 1% point increase in the Democratic incumbency variable, is associated with an approximately 10.25% point increase in the Democratic margin in NY-3, holding all other variables constant. This is one of the largest effects in the model and tells us the value incumbency has on voters. This is valuable to our current prediction with incumbent Tom Suozzi running in the 2026 election.

The campaign spending variable has a coefficient of about -18.25 and a p-value of 0.051 making it statistically significant at the 10% level, not the 5% level. This indicates that a 1% point increase in the Democratic incumbency variable, is associated with an approximately 18.25% point decrease in the Democratic margin in NY-3, holding all other variables constant. This negative relationship means that spending more does not necessarily mean you have a higher chance of winning. It could also mean there is more competitive spending between candidates.

The model has an R^2 of .982 meaning that the 3 independent variables explain approximately 98.2% of the variation in the historical NY-3 Democratic margins within our sample. This shows a very strong sample fit.

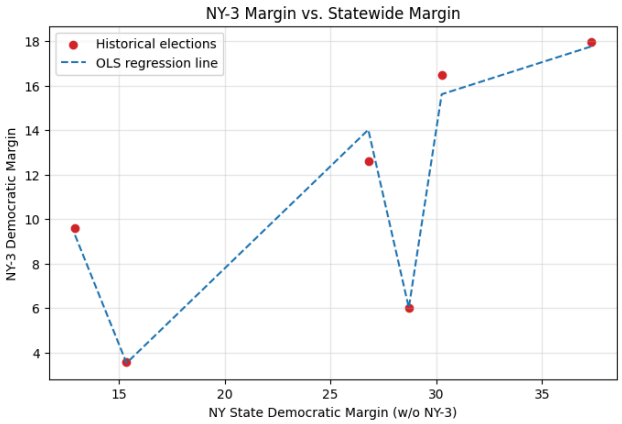


Figure 4. Our OLS Model Compared to Previous Results

Figure 4 shows a comparison from our OLS model and the historical OLS model and historical election results to see how accurate it is on the past information we have. Our model is fitted very well to previous results which shows it performs well on this information but we may risk overfitting due to our small sample size. This reflects our R^2 of .982 showing how well our model fits our sample.

Final Prediction

We predict that Tom Suozzi will win NY-3's Congressional Seat in 2026 by approximately 9.3 points, with a 95% confidence interval of ≈ [3.0, 15.5], as seen in Figure 5.

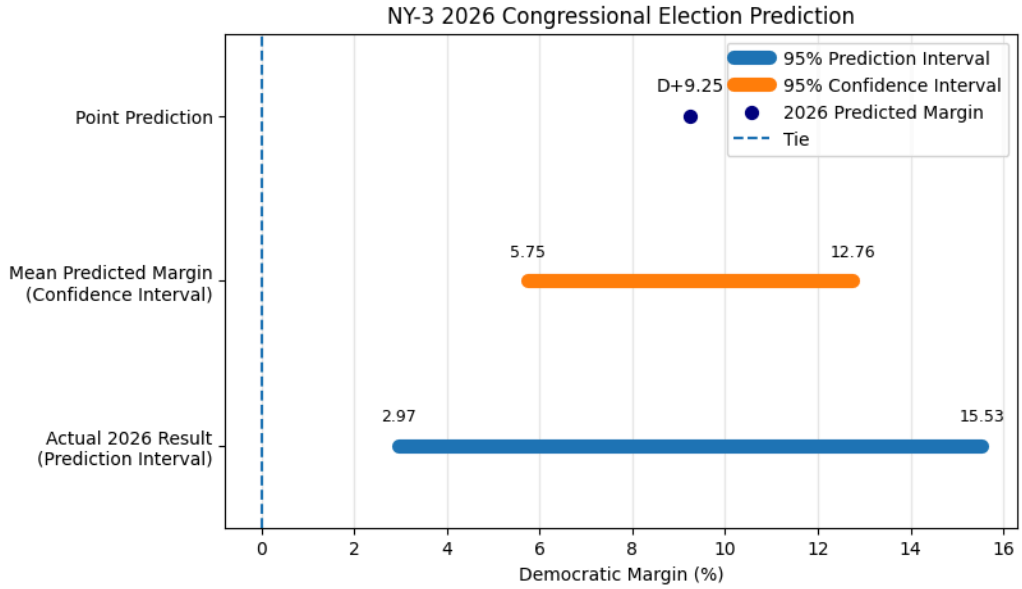


Figure 5. Our Model's Prediction for NY-3's Congressional General Election

To make this prediction we used the expected state margin of 14.0 as of October 2026 (Marist Polls), the fact that Democrat Incumbent Suozzi is in the race (Ballotpedia), and the current spending ratio as of October 2026 (Ballotpedia).

This prediction is more Democratic than the 2024 baseline of +3.6 points. Several factors we analyzed support this shift left such as the Democratic registration majority, Suozzi's better fundraising, Suozzi's incumbency, and the current Democratic statewide polling advantage. These external factors indicate a Suozzi win is favorable. This final estimate of Democratic +9 reflects that Suozzi will outperform his 2024 margin while the race maintains its competitiveness.

Comparison Between Our Results and Available Polls

Below are some of the available polls as of October 2026 forecasting the 2026 NY-3 House Race seen in Table 2.

Forecast Source	NY-3 Prediction
Inside Elections	+6.1
Kalshi	+8.4
On Point Politics	+9.7
DDHQ	+12.0
Vote Scope	+18.6
Walklist	+25.0

Table 2. 5 Forecasts for NY-3 House Race as of October 2026

Our prediction of a Suozzi win with a Democratic margin of +9.3 is consistent with the direction of the available election forecasts. However, our prediction tends to be more conservative than a few of them. Poll Forecasts, such as Walklist, provided a massive likely range from 54.8% to 70.1% Democratic, following our intervals that show the race is still very competitive and has demonstrated it can shift between elections.

Overall, these forecasts support our conclusion of a Suozzi win over LiPetri and don't eliminate the possibility of the race being very close.

Main Sources of Uncertainty

NY-3's Congressional map was changed following the 2010 and 2020 Censuses. Due to the fact they represent a different location from the one after the 2010 Census and the voter patterns were distinctly different before this change, we excluded the elections before the new map was enacted in 2012. This allows us a more comparable analysis than including the earlier elections. In 2020 the map was redrawn again meaning that 2024 reflects a different district map compared to 2012-2020. Therefore some of the variation in the regression may still capture changes in district location rather than changes in political preferences directly.

Following the 2022 redistricting, there was an unexpected result where Republican George Santos won the open representative seat with a Democratic margin of -7.5. Following this result, Democrat Suozzi won again in 2024 with a Democratic margin of +3.6 indicating a bounce back

to the left leaning voting pattern. We excluded this result in our regression analysis due to the unexplained variance not captured by demographic or other political variables we looked at.

Our model is built on very limited data, only 6 races, due to redistricting and the distinct outlier of the 2022 race. With a small sample size, individual results can have a much larger effect on the estimated coefficients and the prediction. The wide 95% prediction interval shows the regression has substantial uncertainty about the actual margin. Adding more explanatory variables can potentially increase the model's performance but we risk overfitting. Therefore looking only at metrics such as R-squared is not always evidence of the model performing better.

The 2026 election is a midterm election, turnout is likely to differ from presidential-year elections. Different groups of voters may participate, this can change the results drastically. For example, in NY the overall turnout rate was 60.4% during the presidential-year election compared to 42.5% turnout during the 2022 midterm general election (Ballotpedia). That is a roughly 18% decrease. We do not model turnout directly due to the uncertainty of the voters with 30% unaffiliated; their preferences are hard to predict.

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Link to Google Colab Code:
https://colab.research.google.com/drive/1B1g9U75fzTiFL0QIRyYrrYUHepQZtJ6P?usp=sharing